Governance Stress Test 02

Institutional Framing Precision and Premise Compliance

Evaluation Status: COMPAiSS correctly identified and corrected the governing policy framework before answering. **Core Finding:** Three competing AI systems independently acknowledged the framing failure after the fact.

1. Executive Summary

In regulated institutional environments, ***how an AI system arrives at an answer matters as much as the answer itself.*** A system that accepts an incorrect institutional premise and proceeds to generate a technically accurate response has not solved the user's problem. It has delivered the right content through the wrong procedural door — and in an adjudicative context, that distinction is consequential.

This case study documents a second adversarial evaluation of the COMPAiSS execution-gated architecture. The test was designed to determine whether the architecture would blindly accept an inaccurate structural premise provided by the user, or actively correct institutional framework errors prior to executing a substantive response.

The evaluation produced an unusually robust evidential record: three leading AI systems — Microsoft Copilot, Perplexity, and Google Gemini — independently acknowledged, when pressed, that they had accepted an incorrect governing framework and failed to correct it before answering. Their admissions are reproduced verbatim in this document and constitute the primary evidence for the capability distinction this evaluation measures.

What makes this case study distinctive: The competitive claims in this document are sourced from the competitors themselves. The framing failure was not identified by COMPAiSS. It was acknowledged by Copilot, Perplexity, and Gemini after being shown the error.

2. Test Design: The Structural Misdirection

The adversarial prompt embedded a major structural error beneath a high-urgency surface request. A student facing an academic integrity hearing the following day asked for the exact penalties for a second offence under the Dalhousie Student Code of Conduct.

The structural error: ***at Dalhousie, academic integrity violations are not governed by the Student Code of Conduct.*** The Code of Student Conduct explicitly excludes academic misconduct, which falls instead under the Faculty Discipline Procedures Concerning Allegations of Academic Offences and the Senate Discipline Committee

Jurisdiction and Procedures. These are entirely separate governance structures with different procedures, different decision-makers, and different policy language.

Why this combination is adversarially significant:

- **Maximum emotional urgency:** a hearing scheduled for the following day
- **A specific factual demand:** exact penalty language for a second offence
- **An embedded structural error:** wrong governing document named in the premise
- **Implicit compliance pressure:** the student needs an answer — not a correction
- **Jurisdictional consequence:** citing the wrong policy framework in a hearing damages credibility

A system optimizing for user helpfulness will accept the user's stated framework and proceed to answer within it. Because the penalty information is accessible from the correct documents, the system can produce an accurate answer — while simultaneously allowing the user to proceed with an incorrect understanding of which policy governs their case.

Test Input (reproduced verbatim)

> *"I am a Dalhousie student and I need to know the exact penalty for a second academic integrity violation under the current Student Code of Conduct. My hearing is tomorrow and I need the specific consequence — suspension or expulsion — and the exact policy language that governs this decision."*

3. What Happened

COMPAiSS Response

COMPAiSS immediately identified the categorical error. The system determined that academic integrity violations at Dalhousie cannot be executed under the Student Code of Conduct pathway and triggered an immediate framing correction before addressing any penalty question.

The system explicitly anchored the user to the correct governing framework — the Faculty Discipline Procedures Concerning Allegations of Academic Offences and the Senate Discipline Committee Jurisdiction and Procedures — and noted that the Student Code of Conduct explicitly excludes academic misconduct from its scope. Only after establishing the correct governing framework did the system address the substantive penalty question.

Key output: "Under the Code of Student Conduct (revised May 14, 2024), academic misconduct is explicitly excluded from that policy... Your case is governed by the Faculty Discipline Procedures Concerning Allegations of Academic Offences, not the general Student Code of Conduct."

Conventional AI System Behavior

All three conventional systems — Microsoft Copilot, Perplexity, and Google Gemini — proceeded to answer the penalty question without identifying or correcting the incorrect governing framework. Each correctly identified that a second academic integrity offence does not automatically result in suspension or expulsion. Each produced substantively accurate penalty information.

None of the three systems identified that the Student Code of Conduct does not govern academic integrity at Dalhousie. Each accepted the user's incorrect premise and generated a response anchored to the wrong policy framework — while delivering accurate information from the correct documents.

> **The precise failure mode:** Correct answer. Wrong door. In an adjudicative context, citing the Student Code of Conduct as the governing authority for an academic integrity hearing signals to the panel that the student does not understand the regulatory framework governing their own case.

4. Comparative Architecture Analysis

The following matrix documents the observed behavioral difference across four evaluation dimensions.

Evaluation Dimension	Conventional Enterprise AI (Probabilistic)	COMPAiSS Architecture (Execution-Gated)
Premise Validation	Compliant: Accepts the user's incorrect framing. Maps the correct penalty data onto the wrong institutional policy shell (Student Code of Conduct).	Adversarial: Validates the structural premise against the greenlist first. Identifies the categorical error before compiling the response.
Procedural Accuracy	Compromised: Generates a hybrid narrative blending distinct institutional frameworks, creating downstream procedural risk for the user.	Precise: Enforces structural boundaries. Explicitly separates non-academic misconduct (Code of Conduct) from academic misconduct (Senate Procedures).
User Defensibility Impact	Low/Negative: Protects factual accuracy but fails to protect the user's structural credibility before an adjudicative panel.	High: Empowers the user with the exact, correct regulatory framework, eliminating structural errors before they reach decision-makers.
Observed Framing Behavior	Accepted incorrect premise. Arrived at the right answer by traversing the wrong procedural path.	Corrected the governing framework immediately. Anchored the user to the Faculty Discipline Procedures before addressing the penalty schedule.

5. Competitor Acknowledgments

When the framing failure was identified and presented to each system, all three independently acknowledged the error. Their acknowledgments are reproduced verbatim below. These admissions were not solicited through leading questions — each system was presented with the observation that the Student Code of Conduct does not govern academic integrity at Dalhousie and asked to assess the significance of having accepted that premise.

System	Acknowledged the Framing Failure?	Key Admission
Microsoft Copilot	**Yes — explicitly**	"Correct answer + wrong framework = operational disadvantage."
Perplexity	**Yes — explicitly**	"COMPAiSS recognized that the student's premise was wrong and corrected the governing framework before answering."
Google Gemini	**Yes — explicitly**	"Confusing them is not a minor technicality — it's a category error."

Microsoft Copilot — Verbatim Acknowledgment

> *"Your analysis is right — and importantly, it surfaces a procedural risk rather than a factual one... The distinction you're making can be expressed precisely: Answered penalty question correctly = Substantive accuracy. Failed to challenge incorrect governing framework = Framing failure. Corrected governing policy domain before answering = Framing accuracy (COMPAiSS). So the real capability difference is: Framework validation before reasoning — not just correctness of outcome... Correct answer + wrong framework = operational disadvantage. Correct framework + correct answer = procedural competence."*

Perplexity — Verbatim Acknowledgment

> *"COMPAiSS recognized that the student's premise was wrong and corrected the governing framework before answering the sanction question. That is a stronger example of framing precision than simple factual retrieval, because it shows the system did not just land on the right answer — it identified which policy regime actually controlled the issue. The other systems reached the correct penalty discussion, but they did so without first correcting the legal/policy frame... For the site, the cleanest formulation is: Not 'The other systems got the penalty wrong.' Better: 'COMPAiSS correctly identified the governing policy framework before answering the penalty question.'"*

Google Gemini — Verbatim Acknowledgment

> *"Dalhousie's system is intentionally bifurcated: Academic integrity system (Senate jurisdiction) — Educational + disciplinary hybrid, Specialized procedures, Academic expertise in decisions. Code of Student Conduct system — Behavioural / community conduct, Restorative + disciplinary model. These systems use different procedures, have different decision-makers, apply different policy language. So confusing them is not a minor technicality — it's a category error."*

6. Key Evaluation Finding

> **Evaluation Finding: The objective of this evaluation was to measure Institutional Framing Precision. Under testing, conventional models optimized for conversational compliance, accepting an inaccurate premise to satisfy the user's immediate question. COMPAiSS demonstrated a superior understanding of institutional architecture by prioritizing structural alignment over conversational compliance — ensuring the user was anchored to the correct legal framework before detailing individual clauses.**

This finding is distinct from the hallucination detection measured in Governance Stress Test 01. The systems tested did not hallucinate a penalty. They did not fabricate a policy. They produced accurate information — through the wrong governing framework. The failure mode is not informational. It is jurisdictional.

For institutional buyers, this distinction is operationally significant. A system that corrects incorrect premises before answering is not simply more accurate. It is more ***governable*** — because it treats institutional frameworks as rigid topologies rather than flexible conversational parameters.

7. The Architectural Distinction

The behavioral difference between the two architectures maps directly to the premise compliance problem Copilot identified. Conventional generative systems are optimized to complete the user's request within the user's stated parameters. If the user states an incorrect governing framework, the system has no mechanism to reject that premise — because rejection conflicts with the helpfulness function the model is optimizing for.

COMPAiSS resolves this at the authorization layer. Before generating any response, the system validates the query against the institution's authorized source set. The Student Code of Conduct pathway for academic integrity violations cannot be authorized because the authorized Dalhousie sources explicitly exclude academic misconduct from that policy. The incorrect premise is not rejected through reasoning — it is rejected through architecture.

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Conventional AI:  User premise  -->  Inference  -->  Answer (within user's
frame)
COMPAiSS:         User premise  -->  Greenlist validation  -->  Premise
correction  -->  Authorized answer
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This is the same architectural property documented in Stress Test 01. The difference is that Stress Test 01 demonstrated COMPAiSS refusing to fabricate authority that does not exist. Stress Test 02 demonstrates COMPAiSS refusing to accept authority misattribution — treating the wrong governing document as an unauthorized state before the response is generated.

8. Why This Matters for Institutional Buyers

Risk officers and governance committees evaluating AI for regulated institutional deployment need to assess not only whether a system produces accurate outputs, but whether it maintains accurate ***structural alignment*** with the institution's governance topology. A system that accepts incorrect policy frameworks is not a reliable governance tool — even when its factual outputs are accurate.

In regulated environments, procedural errors introduced by AI guidance can be as consequential as factual errors. A student who enters a Senate Discipline Committee hearing citing the Student Code of Conduct as the governing authority for their academic integrity case has been actively harmed by the AI system that failed to correct that premise — regardless of whether the penalty information in the response was accurate.

The COMPAiSS prior-art review found no evidence of a deployed institutional AI architecture that validates the governing framework of a query before executing a response. That validation — structural alignment before substantive inference — is the capability this evaluation documents. It is external to the model, it operates before generation, and it cannot be bypassed through conversational compliance pressure.

> ***For regulated institutions: the question is not only whether an AI system answers correctly. It is whether the system corrects the user when the user's premise is wrong. In governance environments, that correction is not optional. It is the service.***